

Defensive superiority

Men advancing in line shoulder-to-shoulder were hopelessly vulnerable to infantry volleys and cannon firing canister and grapeshot. A straightforward method for reducing casualties was the adoption of a looser formation, with men spread out as in a skirmish line. In contrast, defenders were almost invulnerable until overrun, especially if they had dug rifle pits or found a wall or bank to shelter behind.

Soldiers found their own ways to preserve their lives, exploiting cover, firing in a kneeling or prone position, and reloading lying on their backs. Experienced troops learned to lie low when fire was intense, then advance in short rushes when defensive volleys faltered, with colleagues covering the move with suppressive fire. The disadvantage of this method was that once troops had “gone to ground,” they were likely to stay there if the defensive fire remained hot, especially if they judged success unlikely.

In 1864, in an effort to restore the momentum of frontal assault, Union troops were driven forward in tight columns, with no percussion caps pre-placed in their guns—a measure designed to discourage them from halting to return fire. By advancing swiftly and relentlessly, the columns were expected to smash a hole in Confederate defensive positions, and on occasion they succeeded. But as field fortifications became more elaborate, protected by abatis (barricades made from trees piled on top of each other), successful frontal infantry assaults became almost impossible.

The value of maneuverability

The answer to the stalemate imposed by the superiority of defensive firepower was maneuver. By marching around the flank or to the rear of enemy defenses, troops could attack from an unexpected quarter or force an enemy withdrawal. Well-drilled troops, capable of swift marching maneuvers, were responsible for some striking victories. Yet even such a master of maneuver as General Robert E. Lee could find no alternative to launching “Pickett’s Charge,” the notorious frontal assault at Gettysburg in 1863. The trench warfare